

Research Participation Requirements

PURPOSE

Your participation in this program directly contributes to peer-reviewed academic publications that shape future understanding of leadership, motivation, team dynamics, and decision-making. As a participant, you'll observe the research process from the inside—seeing how behavioral scientists design controlled experiments, isolate variables, and collect data. These are the same methods that produce the findings you're studying in BUAD 304.

The program has two phases. First, **registration and setup** (Steps 1 and 2) prepare you for participation: you will register in SONA using your USC NetID, complete a questionnaire, and provide employee contacts for **field research**—surveys sent to real employees in actual workplaces that help researchers access authentic organizational experiences they cannot obtain otherwise. Second, **lab studies** (Step 3) are where you earn your 2.0 research credits—controlled experiments (online or in-person) where you will experience experimental methodology firsthand, seeing how researchers isolate variables, test hypotheses, and collect data.

HOW IT WORKS

Follow the 3-step process below. Steps 1 and 2 are one-time setup tasks that unlock Step 3, where you earn credits by participating in lab studies throughout the semester. Study invitations are time-sensitive—respond within 3 days, as available spots are limited.

ADMINISTRATION

The program is administered by the Marshall Behavioral Research Lab through **SONA** (marshall-mor.sona-systems.com). **Registration is required—it links you to the program and enables study notifications.**

✓ Contact the Lab

The Research Participation Team handles SONA access, study scheduling, credits, and accommodations. mor.sona@marshall.usc.edu · [#buad304-research-participation](#) on Slack (fastest response).

✗ Not Your Instructors or TAs

They can't access SONA, view your credits, or fix study issues. Program questions sent to instructors are referred back to the lab, so contacting the lab directly is always fastest.

1 REGISTER

STEP 1 OF 3

Opens Aug 24 · Deadline Sep 25 · p. 2

 **Register on SONA**
marshall-mor.sona-systems.com

~5 min



SCAN TO REGISTER

 **User ID:** USC NetID (e.g., smithj) · **Student ID:** 10-digit USC ID · **Then:** Check USC email for activation link

2 SETUP

STEP 2 OF 3

Opens Sep 11 · Deadline Sep 25 · pp. 3–6

2A Answer prescreening
Auto-prompts on login

20–30 min

2B Submit 3 employee contacts
Same organization

~5 min

TOTAL TIME
25–35 min

 **Completes setup** → Unlocks Step 3 invitations

ONE-TIME
Setup

3 EARN RESEARCH CREDITS

STEP 3 OF 3

Opens Sep 25 · Deadline Dec 4 · pp. 7–8

 **Complete lab research studies**
Online (5–30 min) or In-Person at VPD Lower Level (15–90 min) · Invitations rotate to all qualified students

3–6 studies

GOAL
2.0 Credits

 **Each Study:** Invite → Sign Up → Complete → Credit · **Repeat 3–6×** to reach 2.0 credits

PER STUDY
0.25–1.5

STEP 1

SONA Registration

Create your research participation account to receive study invitations

REGISTRATION DEADLINE

Sep 25

REGISTRATION URL

marshall-mor.sona-systems.com

SONA (Sona Systems) is a web-based research management platform. It is not connected to USC IT systems or platforms (Blackboard, myUSC, etc.), which is why you must create a separate account. Through SONA, you'll receive study invitations, complete prescreening, sign up for studies, and track credit progress. Registration links you to the MOR Subject Pool—a one-time setup. **Check your USC email after registering** for an activation link (check your spam/junk folder if you don't see it within a few minutes). You must click it to receive study invitations. Below are simplified previews of the two SONA screens you'll complete during registration.

CREDITS REQUIRED

2.0

RESEARCH CREDITS

CREDIT	TIME
0.25	5–15 min
0.50	~30 min
1.00	up to 60 min
1.50	up to 90 min
0.25 credit per 15 min of study time	

WHAT YOU NEED

- ☐ Your USC NetID (e.g., smithj)
- ☐ Your 10-digit USC ID number
- ☐ Your course section number
- ☐ About 5 minutes

TECHNICAL REQUIREMENTS

Desktop or laptop required—mobile devices won't work unless a study specifically states otherwise.

BROWSER	MAC	PC
Chrome	✓	✓
Safari	✓	—
Edge	—	✓
Firefox	✓	✓

⚠ Don't Confuse Sites:

BUAD 307 (Marketing) has a similar SONA site with a yellow color scheme—it's completely separate.

A Go to SONA & Request Account
marshall-mor.sona-systems.com

USC Marshall
School of Business

Management and Organization (MOR)

RESEARCH PARTICIPATION FOR BUAD 304 & 497

User ID

@usc.edu

Password

Log In

Request Account

Forgot Password?

New students: Click "Request Account"

B Complete Registration Form
marshall-mor.sona-systems.com/student_new_user.aspx

ACCOUNT INFORMATION

First Name

Last Name

User ID

@usc.edu

Enter your NetID only (e.g., "smithj")

Student ID Number

Your 10-digit USC ID

Course

BUAD 304 (your section) ▼

Select the section you're enrolled in

HOW YOU'LL RECEIVE STUDY INVITATIONS

All announcements and study opportunities are sent through SONA to registered students only—your course instructors will not send these. You must register to receive program information.



SCAN: WATCH TUTORIAL

bit.ly/SONA-BUAD304

3-min video walkthrough



SCAN: REGISTER NOW

marshall-mor.sona-systems.com

HOW RESEARCH CREDITS AFFECT YOUR GRADE

Your research credits determine your score on the **Research Participation** component of your course grade (see main syllabus for weight). Earning all 2.0 credits = 100% of that component. Partial credits are prorated as shown. **No extensions are granted.** Plan ahead—most students need the full 10-week study period to complete all credits.

2.0
100%1.5
75%1.0
50%0.0
0%

STEP 2A

Prescreening Questionnaire

Support for completing the prescreening questionnaire in SONA

📅 Deadline: September 25, 2026

Step 2 has two parts that must be completed in order. Both are prerequisites that unlock Step 3 study invitations—neither earns research credits directly. Complete 2A first (unlocks 2B), then complete 2B to begin receiving study invitations.

2A

PRESCREENING QUESTIONNAIRE

Available Sep 11

Deadline September 25

Support: mor.sona@marshall.usc.edu

Twenty to thirty minutes • Complete first. When available, this questionnaire will appear automatically when you log into SONA—there is no need to search for it. The questionnaire collects information about your demographics and experiences. Provide accurate responses, as they determine which studies you will be invited to participate in. The questionnaire must be completed in one uninterrupted sitting (progress cannot be saved). Completion unlocks Step 2B. **Available starting September 11, 2026.**

SAMPLE

What to Expect: Prescreening Question Types

Demographics

- What is your age?
- What is your ethnicity?
- What is your first language?

Background

- What is your year at USC?
- What is your major?
- Are you currently employed?

Attitudes & Preferences

- Rate 1–5: "I enjoy working in teams"
- Rate 1–5: "I prefer structure"
- Rate 1–5: "I take initiative"

2B

EMPLOYEE CONTACT SUBMISSION

Available after 2A

Deadline September 25

About five minutes • After completing 2A. Submit contact information for three people from the same organization: a focal employee, their coworker, and their supervisor. Your role ends at submission—once you enter the contacts, Step 2B is complete and you can begin receiving Step 3 study invitations. The research team handles everything else: sending surveys in late October 2026 (after Fall Recess), collecting responses, and notifying you when all three have completed their surveys.

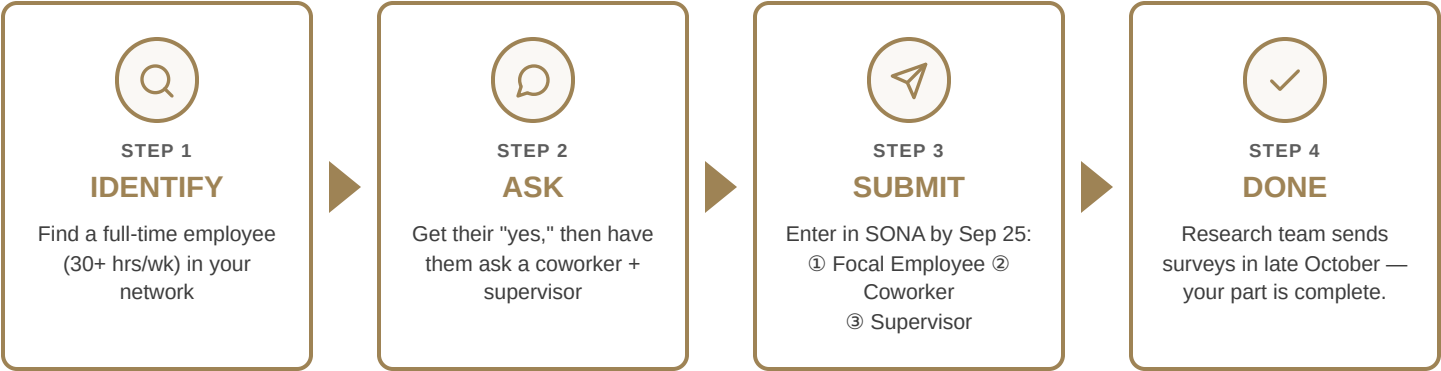
✉ 2B Support

Questions about contacts?

mor.research@usc.edu

(Note: different from 2A)

YOUR PROCESS FOR 2B



STEP 2B

Employee Contact Submission

Field research contribution · Who you need and where to find them

WHO YOU NEED & WHERE TO FIND THEM

For Step 2B, you'll submit contact information for three people from the same organization. Here's who qualifies and where to find them.

You contact one employee — they coordinate participation from their coworker and supervisor



YOU CONTACT

FOCAL EMPLOYEE
Your main contact

THEY RECRUIT



2

COWORKER

Colleague of Focal Employee

3

SUPERVISOR

Focal Employee's manager

Why Three People?



Focal Emp.



Coworker



Supervisor

Complete
Picture

Organizational behavior research requires multiple perspectives on the same workplace. By surveying all three, researchers can study questions like: Do employees and supervisors perceive leadership the same way? These multi-source insights are not possible with single-person surveys.

Who Qualifies?

All three participants must work 30+ hours per week—contractors and temps qualify if they meet this threshold. The **Focal Employee** is your main contact: the person you reach out to directly, who then recruits their coworker and supervisor. The coworker and supervisor must both work with the Focal Employee, but they do not need to interact with each other. All three must work for the same employer (different locations or departments are fine, but different franchise owners count as separate organizations). You'll need **work email addresses** for all three—personal emails cannot be used.

Where to Find Your Focal Employee



Parents

Most common source



Extended Family

Aunts, uncles, cousins



Family Friends

Parents' colleagues



Your Workplace

If employed full-time



LinkedIn Network

Professional connections



Past Internships

Former supervisors, mentors



Sports & Clubs

Coaches, teammates' parents



Community Service

Volunteer org contacts

✗ Ineligible Contacts

- **Part-time employees** — all three must work 30+ hrs/week
- **Personal email addresses** — work emails required
- **Different employers** — all three must share same employer
- **Different franchise owners** — counts as separate organizations

✓ Before You Submit, Confirm

- ☐ All three work at the **same organization**
- ☐ All three work **30+ hours/week**
- ☐ You have **work emails** (not personal) for all three
- ☐ Coworker and supervisor both **work with Focal Employee**
- ☐ All three have **agreed to participate**

Tips for Success

✓ **Confirm first:** Secure agreement from all three before opening SONA.

👥 **Expect 3–5 attempts:** Most students contact several people before finding a match.

👤 **You contact one:** They recruit their coworker and supervisor for you.

READY-TO-USE TEMPLATES & TALKING POINTS

Use these scripts when reaching out to potential contacts. Customize as needed for your relationship.

Email Template

To: [Recipient's work email]

Subject: Request to Participate in USC Marshall Workplace Research

Dear [Name],

I'm enrolled in an organizational behavior course at the USC Marshall School of Business and am contributing to research on workplace dynamics. I'm hoping you can help—**my deadline to submit names is September 25, 2026.**

The research team needs survey responses from three people at the same organization: an employee, one of their coworkers, and their supervisor. These three perspectives allow researchers to study how the same workplace is perceived from different roles.

Here is what participation involves: A thirty-minute survey about workplace experiences (can be paused and resumed), sent via email in late October 2026 from mor.research@usc.edu, completely voluntary and confidential—responses never shared with employers.

If you are willing to participate, could you ask one coworker and your immediate supervisor if they would also be willing? Once all three agree, I would just need each person's name and **work email address** so the research team can send the survey invitations directly.

I truly appreciate you considering this request.

Thank you,
[Your Name]

Sample Text Conversation

Hi! Would you help with a USC class project? It's a 30-min workplace survey in late October.

Sure, what do I need to do?

Ask a coworker + your supervisor if they'd also do it. I just need names and work emails for all 3.

When do you need it by?

September 25, 2026. Thank you!

Phone Script

Opening: "Hi [Name], this is [Your Name]. Do you have a minute?"

Ask: "I'm taking a class at USC Marshall. Would you take a 30-min workplace survey in late October?"

If yes: "Could you also ask a coworker and your supervisor? I just need names and work emails."

Close: "Everything is confidential. My deadline is September 25, 2026. Thanks!"

Talking Points**CONTEXT & THE ASK**

"I'm taking an organizational behavior course at USC Marshall and contributing to workplace research. Would you be willing to complete a survey—and if so, ask one coworker and your supervisor if they'd participate too?"

TIME, WHEN & HOW

"About 30 minutes each. You can pause and resume anytime. Surveys go out in late October 2026 via email from mor.research@usc.edu."

WHY ALL THREE

"The research studies how employees, coworkers, and supervisors each see the same workplace—so all three perspectives are needed to make the data complete."

PRIVACY & WHAT YOU NEED

"Completely voluntary and confidential—your employer never sees individual responses. Once they agree, I just need names and **work email addresses** (not personal emails) for all three."

Why does SONA show "0 credits" after completing Step 2? Steps 2A and 2B are prerequisites that unlock Step 3 study invitations—they don't award credits themselves. Your research credits come from completing lab studies in Step 3.

SUBMITTING YOUR CONTACTS

WHERE TO FIND THE FORM

After completing Step 2A, the Step 2B submission form will appear in your SONA account as a study listing (this is how we track submissions automatically). Click the link to access the contact submission form. Note: This only appears for BUAD 304 students.

DOUBLE-CHECK ACCURACY

Verify all names and email addresses before submitting—errors cannot be easily corrected after submission. Most students successfully complete this requirement through family members, family friends, or personal connections.

CONFIRMATION

After successful submission, you'll see "0 credits" posted to your SONA account. This is expected: Step 2B isn't a credit-bearing study; it's a required setup step. The "0 credits" entry simply confirms your submission went through and activates your eligibility for lab study invitations (where you'll earn your 2.0 credits).

You'll also receive an automated confirmation email from mor.research@usc.edu summarizing the contacts you entered. Review this carefully to ensure everything looks correct. If you spot an error, contact mor.research@usc.edu immediately.

WHAT HAPPENS NEXT

After you submit, the research team takes over—**your role is complete**:

SUBMISSION REVIEW

The research team audits all submissions to verify emails are valid and contacts work at the same organization. If we find issues—typos, mismatched companies, bounced addresses—we'll contact you to make corrections. Make sure you're checking your USC email.

SURVEYS DISTRIBUTED

Your contacts receive survey invitations from mor.research@usc.edu in late October 2026. Each survey takes about 30 minutes and can be paused and resumed—your contacts don't have to complete it in one sitting. They'll have a few weeks from the initial invitation to respond.

REMINDERS SENT AUTOMATICALLY

The research team follows up with contacts who haven't responded. You don't need to send reminders yourself.

YOUR PART IS DONE

Step 2B is complete once you submit—you don't need to do anything else. Your contacts' survey responses don't affect your status, though responses from all three make the research most valuable.

QUESTIONS FROM YOUR CONTACTS?

Employees with questions about the survey can contact the research team directly at mor.research@usc.edu.

Q PREPARE YOUR CONTACTS

Ask your focal employee to let their coworker and supervisor know: "Watch for an email from mor.research@usc.edu in late October—it's a legitimate USC research study I signed us up for. Check your spam folder if you don't see it."

2

Setup complete — ready for

3

Earn Credits →

STEP 3

Earn Research Credits

Lab research studies — the only step that earns credits toward your 2.0 requirement

 **Deadline: December 4, 2026**

After setup (Steps 1, 2A, and 2B), study invitations arrive via USC email. **Only Step 3 earns research credits toward your 2.0 requirement.** Each invitation email contains a unique link—you must use this link to sign up. You cannot sign up by browsing SONA directly; only invited students can access each study. Most students complete **3–6 studies** over the semester.

How invitations work: The research team rotates through all qualified students evenly—you don't need to constantly check SONA or compete for spots. Since individual studies can't accommodate all ~1,500 students at once, invitations go out in staggered waves throughout the semester. Monitor your USC email and respond promptly when invitations arrive.

See a study in SONA but weren't invited? Studies may appear in SONA before all invitation waves go out. If you can see a study listed but didn't receive an email invitation, you're simply not in the current wave—this is normal. Don't try to sign up without an invitation link. Your turn will come as invitations rotate to all qualified students.

What affects timing: When you receive invitations depends on when you completed setup, compatibility with specific study criteria (from your 2A responses), weekly study availability, and your participation history. These factors affect timing and sequence—not whether you'll reach 2.0 research credits.

Quality matters: Valid research requires thoughtful responses, distraction-free environments, and thorough reading of instructions.

Lab research studies vs. field research studies: Step 3 involves *lab research studies*—controlled experiments conducted either online or in the behavioral research lab where researchers can carefully design conditions and measure responses. This differs from the *field research studies* you contributed to in Step 2B, where surveys go to real employees in their actual workplaces to capture authentic organizational experiences. Both types are essential: lab studies establish cause-and-effect relationships, while field studies confirm that findings hold true in real-world settings.

HOW STUDIES WORK

Step 3 lab research studies are available in **two formats: Online and In-Person**. Both earn the same research credits (0.25 credit per 15 minutes of study time), so choose whichever fits your schedule. You can mix formats throughout the semester—there's no requirement to do all of one type. Study invitations will indicate which format applies.

ONLINE STUDIES

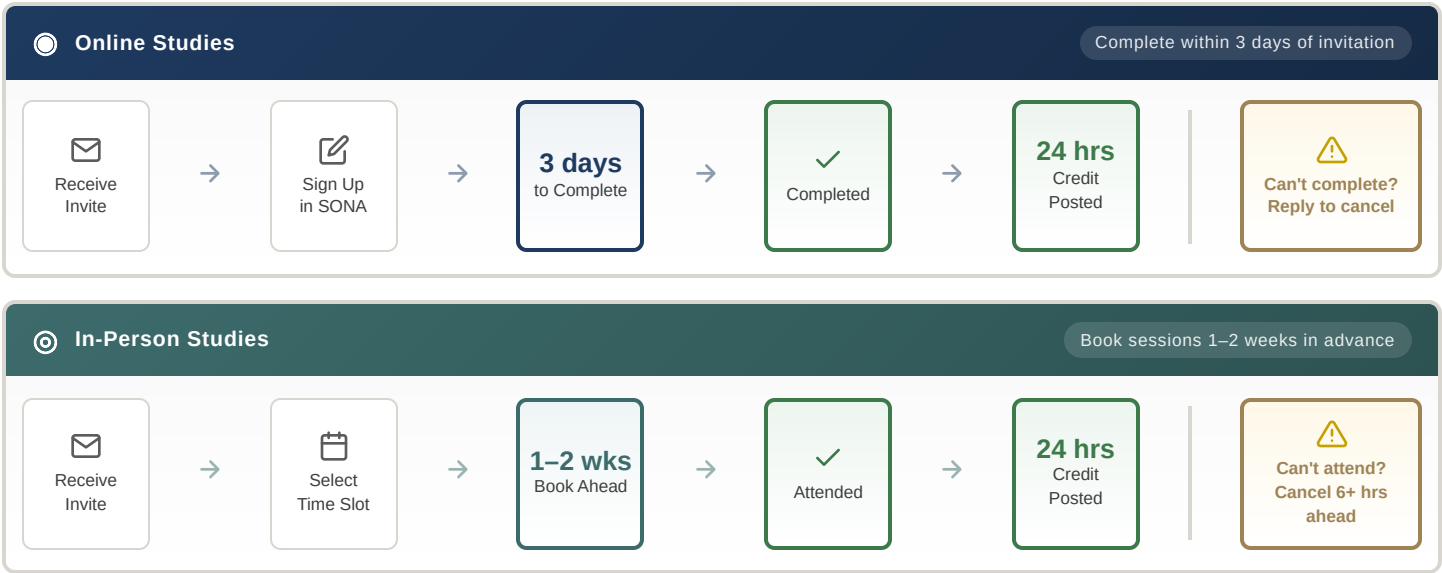
Duration: 5–30 minutes. **Window:** 3 days from invite to complete.
Tech: Desktop/laptop, stable internet, audio capability.
You'll receive an email with a unique link. Click to sign up in SONA, then immediately begin the study in your browser. Find a quiet place, silence your phone, and give it your full attention. Once started, you must finish—there's no saving progress. When done, you'll see a confirmation screen and credits post automatically.

IN-PERSON STUDIES

Location: VPD Lower Level (LL102, LL110, LL112). **Directions:** bit.ly/find-the-lab. **Duration:** 15–90 minutes. **Scheduling:** Book 1–2 weeks ahead. **Cancellation:** 6+ hours notice required.
You'll receive an email invitation to book a time slot. Arrive a few minutes early with your USC ID. Ring the doorbell at your assigned room and a researcher will greet you. You may be alone or with other participants. Follow the researcher's instructions, complete the tasks, and you may leave once dismissed. Credits post within 24 hours.

From Invite to Credit

Here's what the participation process looks like for each study format:



Attendance Policy

Reliable attendance ensures research quality and keeps you eligible for future study invitations:

MISSED INVITATION WINDOW

Expired invitation codes cannot be reactivated. If the 3-day response window has passed, you must wait for subsequent study invitations.

EXCUSED ABSENCES

Cancellations made 6 or more hours in advance with a valid reason (illness, emergency) are considered excused.

UNEXCUSED ABSENCES

Failure to attend without notice or late cancellations result in deprioritization for future study invitations. Repeated no-show incidents significantly limit future participation opportunities.

In-Person Lab Location

FINDING THE LAB

Verna and Peter Dauterive Hall (VPD) Lower Level, 635 Downey Way, Los Angeles, CA 90089. Enter the building, take stairs down to LL, and ring the doorbell at your assigned room (LL102, LL110, or LL112). **Step-by-step directions:** [bit.ly/find-the-lab](#) · **Google Maps:** [Open in Maps](#)

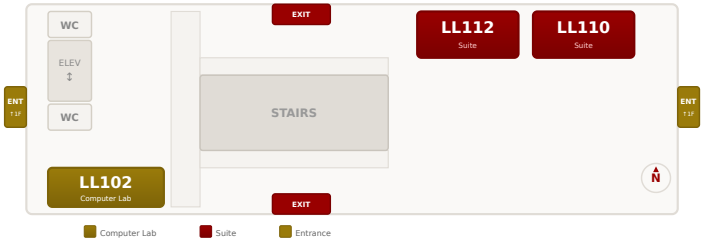


What to look for: VPD at 635 Downey Way



Scan for directions

LOCATION



VPD Lower Level
Verna and Peter Dauterive Hall

Common Questions & Troubleshooting

Answers to frequently asked questions about study invitations, signups, and technical issues, plus alternative pathways

COMMON QUESTIONS

HOW MANY STUDIES?

Most students complete 3–6 studies depending on individual study duration. Complete setup by the deadline to ensure sufficient participation opportunities.

NO INVITATIONS YET?

Ensure both Steps 2A and 2B are complete. Study invitations begin distribution after the September 25, 2026 setup deadline.

MISSED AN INVITE?

The invitation expires and cannot be reactivated. You remain in rotation for future studies—respond promptly when the next invitation arrives.

SEE A STUDY BUT CAN'T SIGN UP?

Studies may be visible in SONA before your invitation wave. If you see a study but didn't receive an email with a unique link, you're not in the current wave—wait for your invitation. Don't try to sign up without one.

HOW DO I SIGN UP?

Each invitation email contains a unique link. Click that link to sign up—you cannot sign up by browsing SONA directly. The link is valid for 3 days; respond promptly as spots are limited.

WHEN WILL I GET INVITES?

Timing depends on when you completed setup, your 2A responses, and study availability. Invitations rotate to all qualified students—if you completed setup by Sep 25, you're guaranteed enough opportunities.

ADDED THE CLASS LATE?

You can still participate. Setup (Steps 1, 2A, and 2B) runs through September 25, 2026 no matter when you enrolled—complete it by the deadline and study invitations will follow like everyone else's.

SHOULD I ASK MY PROFESSOR OR TA?

No—instructors and TAs can't access SONA, view your credits, or resolve study issues; program questions are referred back to the lab. Email mor.sona@marshall.usc.edu or post in #buad304-research-participation for the fastest answer.

TROUBLESHOOTING

For any issues below, contact mor.sona@marshall.usc.edu with specific details for prompt resolution.

CREDITS NOT APPEARING?

Credits are posted within 24 hours of study completion. If credits have not appeared after this period, email us with the study name and completion date.

UNABLE TO LOG IN?

Use the "Forgot Password" function. Remember that your username is your NetID only—the part before @usc.edu in your email address (e.g., smithj), not your full email.

TECHNICAL ISSUES?

Contact us immediately with specific details including error messages, browser used, and steps that led to the issue.

ALTERNATIVE PATHWAYS

Options for students who cannot complete standard research participation requirements. Contact mor.sona@marshall.usc.edu as early as possible.

AGE REQUIREMENT

Students must be 18+ by **October 23, 2026** to participate in research studies. If you will not reach 18 by this date, contact us **immediately** (no later than September 25, 2026) to arrange an approved alternative. Do not wait until the last minute—alternatives require advance planning and instructor coordination.

EXTENDED LAB PARTICIPATION

If unable to find employee contacts for Step 2B, you may complete **3.0 total research credits** (instead of 2.0)—approximately 60 minutes extra participation. Complete Step 2A first, then select this option when Step 2B becomes available in SONA. Note: Limited study availability may present scheduling challenges, especially late in the semester.

WRITTEN ASSIGNMENT OPTION

For documented circumstances preventing any research participation: Three analytical papers (3 pages each) on pre-approved organizational behavior topics. This serves as a complete replacement for all research requirements. Requires documented justification and instructor approval by **September 25, 2026**. This option is reserved for exceptional circumstances only.

Important: These alternatives exist to ensure all students can fulfill course requirements regardless of individual circumstances. However, the standard research participation path is strongly encouraged as it provides direct exposure to organizational behavior research methods. Contact us early if you anticipate needing an alternative—last-minute requests are difficult to accommodate.

